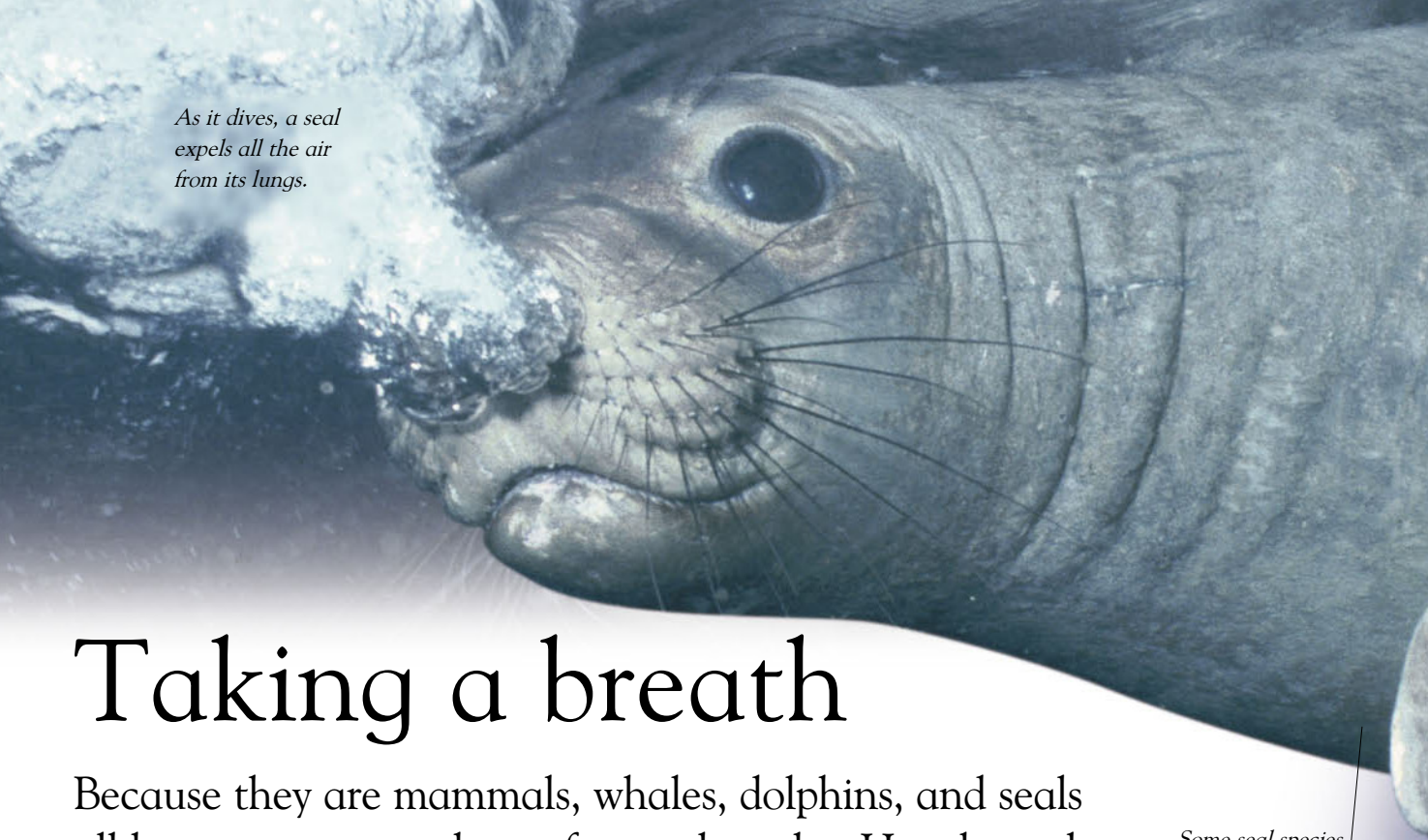




*As it dives, a seal
expels all the air
from its lungs.*

Taking a breath

Because they are mammals, whales, dolphins, and seals all have to come to the surface to breathe. How long they stay underwater after taking a breath varies from a few minutes to about two hours, depending on the species.

*Some seal species
can dive to depths
of more than
3,000 ft (900 m).*



*Strong muscles around
the blowhole close it
before the animal dives.*

One hole...

A whale's blowhole—a muscular opening that leads to the animal's lungs—is positioned on the top of its head. Toothed whales, such as orcas, belugas, and dolphins, have only one blowhole.

...or two

Baleen whales, such as the humpback, have two blowholes. The skin around the blowhole is very sensitive, so the whale knows when it is clear of the water and it is safe to open it.

